

Music Appreciation in Secondary Schools: Challenges and Prospects

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Abstract

With the deepening and development of Nigeria's new round of curriculum reform, senior high school education has increasingly emphasized the comprehensive cultivation of students' overall quality, covering morality, intelligence, physical fitness, aesthetics, labour, and cultural literacy. As an important part of senior high school education, music courses are not only a key carrier for enhancing students' aesthetic taste but also effectively relieve academic pressure and enrich their spiritual world. However, music education, despite being a vital part of the Nigerian educational landscape, still faces many practical difficulties, such as insufficient school attention, weak students' interest in music learning, poor reserve of music theoretical knowledge, unclear assessment criteria for music appreciation ability, and insufficient consideration of the feasibility of teaching reforms in different regional contexts. Another challenge is lack of professional music teachers in most secondary schools in Nigeria. This paper posits that musical arts education holds immense potential in contributing to the realisation of massive developmental growth in Nigeria, while simultaneously aligning with the aspirations of the Sustainable Development Goals. Therefore, this paper adopts descriptive methodology as guide. Based on this, the paper concludes by recommending that government as well as private school stakeholders should ensure that they hire music teachers with Nigerian certificate in education (NCE) or first degree in music education since this was found to influence the level of interest students have for music education.

Keywords: Music Appreciation, Secondary, Schools, Challenges Prospects.

Introduction

Music education in school practice is still perceived in a very traditional way, without taking into consideration the dynamics of societal development and the need for qualitatively new competencies (Abiodun, 2018). It is, therefore, important to monitor the changes in music education, and its challenges and to find ways to improve the teaching process. According to Genders (2023) the teacher's competencies are one of the most important factors in ensuring education, because student's learning and teaching results depend on their use during the educational process.

Music appreciation ability is a core component of students' aesthetic literacy and an important manifestation of their comprehensive quality development. The new round of basic education curriculum reform clearly states that senior high school music teaching should focus on the goal of "aesthetic education", guiding students to feel the charm of music, understand its connotation, and form independent musical aesthetic judgments (Fahed & Steffens, 2021).

Existing global research on music pedagogy has laid a solid theoretical foundation for this field. For example, Dalcroze's eurhythmics emphasizes the connection between body movement and

music perception, Kodály's method highlights the combination of national music culture and music education, and Orff's approach advocates integrating music, movement, and language to stimulate students' inherent musicality. In the field of aesthetic education, Dewey's Theory of Aesthetic Experience according to Fahed & Steffens (2021) emphasizes the interaction between students and artworks, emphasizing that aesthetic development come from personal emotional experience and cognitive participation. However, under the inertia of exam-oriented education in Nigeria, music courses in senior high schools are often regarded as "non-core subjects" (Mehrad & Tajer, 2016). Problems such as insufficient allocation of teaching resources, rigid teaching methods, unclear assessment criteria for music appreciation ability, and inadequate consideration of regional differences in reform feasibility are widespread, making it difficult for students to truly engage with and understand music. The cultivation of appreciation ability has fallen into a "formalized" predicament. Although school music is not always compulsory, many schools require participation in music through the primary grades. At the secondary level, students typically elect to participate in music, which may mean joining an ensemble or enrolling in classes such as guitar, piano, music appreciation, theory, or music technology. Yet, even when students wish to participate, barriers may exist that prevent their participation at the secondary level (Timothy & Emenike, 2013).

Given the ubiquitous nature of music in our society and its important role in art, entertainment, spirituality, and education, it is imperative that music teachers examine ways to empower students to continue developing musical knowledge throughout their school experience (Samuel, 2017). Students are inherently musical and enter classrooms with a passion for music that is expressed in ways not always recognized in formal school music settings. In this article, we discuss factors that can influence participation in secondary school music and suggest practices to increase access for all students. By illuminating potential barriers and offering suggestions for pathways through them, the researcher aims at empowering music teachers to examine their music programs alongside stakeholders in the community (e.g., students, parents, community members, administrators) to effect meaningful change and promote an inclusive model of music education in their schools. Before developing solutions, teachers must consider the nature of the community, the potential barriers faced in a specific context, and the most appropriate ways through for that setting.

Concepts of Music

Music is a language of its own with expressive and communicative elements. Music has been studied as an art, a science, a therapy, and a power. Music is sound organized in a meaningful way, and may include a melody, harmony, rhythm, and form. Music can be performed by one voice or instrument, or by many—and it can even be performed as silence. The ancient Greeks believed music was cosmically related to science and culture. Harmony in all matters from the spiral growth patterns seen in nature to geometry and good government. This magical connection between sound and form was thought to be integral in maintaining harmony at all levels of society. Various musical modes were used to create desired moods such as calming or stimulating. Believing these modes resonated within the endocrine system in the human body, the ancient Greeks embraced music as much more than an expressive art (Okechukwu, 2025).

The power of music according to Michael (2024) is not merely abstract but is also physical. Physicists and other scientists have concluded that all matter is composed of energy or vibration.

The air vibrations of sound are real and measurable, capable of shattering glass. Music and other sounds cause all kinds of sympathetic vibratory resonances within objects at a distance. Contemporary research into sounds of a lower frequency than is audible to the human ear suggests that nausea or headaches can be caused by sounds produced by industrial machinery from a distance. Rhythm, another measurable force, according to Odeme (2024) is the rationale behind commanding officers' ordering troops to break step when crossing a bridge marching in unison. The rhythmic effect of marching in step can lead to the collapse of the bridge.

They asserted that mathematical laws of music were the same as the laws that regulated Davis (2018) argue that music is a human activity because it plays functional and aesthetic roles in the life of the individual and the society at large. Music is defined by Clifton (1983) as an ordered arrangement of sounds and silences whose meaning is representative rather than denotative. According to Epperson (2022), Music is the actualization of the possibility of any sound whatever to present to some human being a meaning which he experiences with his body - that is to say, with his mind, his feelings, his senses, his will, and his metabolism. Music as a primary human activity is a means by which humans generate their own spiritual, social and cultural niche. Music connects people mutually with other people who share analogous interests with them. It helps keep a record of, give proof, verify and authenticate the history of social and cultural changes in the society. It is the opinion of Eze, Ezenwafor, & Obidil (2017) that, —since music is an aspect as well as an avenue for cultural expression; it is fully embedded in the stream of the daily life of people and occurs in response to religious, economic and political needs.

Music is present in every society and culture; wherever one turns, music will be found to play important functions because of its profound relationship with the daily life of the individual and the life of the society at large. Fahed and Steffens (2021) in his own explanation of why and how music and dance are so important to people's understanding of themselves and their identities states that —although many societies around the world do not have a single concept translatable with the English word music, activities akin to what we call music and dance are practiced among people everywhere and have been throughout history. The reason this is so, according to him, is that —Music, dance, festivals and other public expressive cultural practices are a primary way that people articulate the collective identities that are fundamental to forming and sustaining social groups, which are, in turn, basic to survival (Mehrad & Tajer, 2016).

Music is profoundly interwoven into the fabric of Nigerian society, serving not merely as entertainment but as a cornerstone of cultural expression, historical transmission, and social cohesion. Across its more than 250 ethnic groups, indigenous music plays a pivotal role in daily life, communal rites, ceremonies, and the informal education of younger generations, transmitting values, narratives, and social norms (Davis, 2018). Historically, the transmission of musical knowledge was an intrinsic part of community life, ensuring the continuity of unique cultural identities (Mehrad, & Tajer, 2016). However, in an increasingly globalized world, traditional Nigerian music and the cultural identities it embodies face significant challenges, including the pervasive influence of Western popular culture and the marginalization of indigenous arts within formal education systems. This situation raises critical questions about the effectiveness of current educational practices in safeguarding Nigeria's rich musical heritage (Michael, 2024).

Music, according to Epperson (2022), varies in definition with respect to various cultures,

though it is an aspect of all human societies and a cultural universal. Odeme (2024) also argued that while scholars agree that music is defined by a few specific elements, there is no consensus on their precise definitions. However, it is noted that music is the art of arranging sounds to create a combination of form, harmony, melody, rhythm, or otherwise expressive content. Music could be described as a creative construction in sound for social and aesthetic reasons (Okechukwu, 2025). It is obvious that music plays a significant role in socialising every human being, especially students who are teenagers. Teenagers and students listen to various genres of music like rap, heavy metal, Christian rock, country music, jazz, electrical music, and dance music, among others. Music involving rap, hip hop, hard rock and Christian rock has become the most popular types of music among teenagers (Mishra, Desul, Santos, et al 2023).

Historical of Music Trajectory and Approaches in Nigeria

The advent of formal education, largely introduced by Christian missionaries and the British colonial administration, brought with it a Western-centric curriculum that often marginalized or overlooked indigenous musical forms (Effiong, 2018). Early music education in schools predominantly focused on Western classical music, hymn singing, and European theoretical concepts. While this introduced new musical traditions and pedagogical methods, it also created disconnect from the rich local heritage, inadvertently contributing to the perception of indigenous music as less "academic" or "develop" (Ogunrinade, 2013).

Post-independence, there have been increasing calls and attempts to indigenize the curriculum, including music education (Okunade & Abiodun, 2017). Scholars and educators recognized the urgent need to integrate Nigerian traditional music into formal school settings to foster cultural awareness and pride. Successes in this area include the establishment of departments of music in universities, some of which actively research and teach Nigerian musical forms, and the inclusion of indigenous music in the National Policy on Education. However, these efforts have faced significant challenges (Effiong, 2018). Curricula often remain skewed towards Western paradigms, teacher training in indigenous music is inadequate, and resources for instruments and teaching materials are limited. Moreover, the pervasive influence of global pop culture often competes with, and sometimes overshadows, traditional musical forms among younger generations (Onyeji, 2017).

This explains Onyeji's ideology when he stated that "in Nigeria, the teaching of music is common because involvement with music is considered a fundamental component of the indigenous African culture". Abiodun (2018) stated that since the 1950s, the governments of the western and eastern regions of Nigeria have invested more of their revenues in education than in any other sector of development. This was a shift from the old colonial system in which education, consisting mainly of literacy and numeracy, served only to provide workers for the Colonial Civil Service (Davis, 2018). Government has also stated that for the benefit of all citizens the country's educational goals in terms of its relevance to the needs of the individual as well as in terms of the kind of society desired in relation to the environment and the realities of the modern world and rapid social changes should be clearly set out (Abrams, 2015).

Current Situations of Cultivating Students Appreciation ability in Music Teaching

There are a lot of situations or challenges that may affect proper appreciation. They may, according to He, Z., Zaharul, L. and Bin, S. (2025) are:

1. Insufficient Attention to Teaching and Imbalanced Resource Allocation

Most senior high schools according to He, Zaharul and Bin focus their teaching on college entrance examination core subjects. The class hours of music courses are compressed, and even "occupied or diverted" in some cases. Schools have obvious insufficient investment in music teaching resources, lacking professional music teachers and inadequate equipment such as musical instruments and multimedia teaching tools, which are difficult to meet the basic needs of appreciation teaching (Eze, Ezenwafor, & Obidil, 2017). There are significant differences in resource allocation between urban and rural schools. Urban schools have relatively sufficient funds to purchase advanced teaching equipment, invite professional musicians to give lectures, and organize students to participate in off-campus music activities. In contrast, rural and underfunded schools face more severe challenges, such as a shortage of full-time music teachers, outdated or insufficient musical instruments, and limited access to online music resources due to poor network conditions (He, Zhenge, Zaharul, 2025).

2. Rigid and Single Teaching Methods, Lack of Interactive Experience

Current senior high school music teaching mostly adopts the traditional mode of "teacher plays—students listen—teacher explains", which lacks interest and interactivity. Teachers overemphasize the inculcation of music theoretical knowledge, ignoring students' subjective feelings and experiences. This leads to students passively accepting knowledge, being unable to actively participate in the music appreciation process, and their learning interest gradually fades. (He, Zhenge, Zaharul, 2025). The lack of integration of cognitive and affective learning theories in teaching methods makes it difficult to mobilize students' emotional resonance while imparting knowledge. Students can only memorize superficial theoretical knowledge but cannot deeply understand the emotional connotation and cultural background of music works (Okechukwu, 2025).

3. Uneven Student Foundation and Weak Theoretical Reserve

There are significant differences in the music foundation of senior high school students. Some students lack basic music common sense and have vague cognition of core concepts such as musical notes, rhythm, and melody. At the same time, the types of music students are exposed to be relatively single, mostly confined to pop music. They have little understanding of diverse musical forms such as classical music and national music, resulting in a narrow appreciation perspective and difficulty in forming systematic appreciation thinking (Epperson, 2022).

Findings, Solutions, Prospects and Implications

The development of music in general has been proven to contribute positively to the development of any nation. In Nigeria in particular, music in terms of being a performing art has seen tremendous development. Of recent, it is no more news that some Nigerian artists have contributed successfully to global hits and have continued to attract music investors globally to Nigeria. It is also observable that many Nigerian song items have been topping global music chart. And of recent, it has been accredited to certain Nigerian artists that their musical items have hit billions of views and streams online. This being the case, it is obvious that one cannot say that one can develop total mastery of music without having the knowledge of the rudiments or foundations of music.

Unfortunately, musical apathy has been a source of concern for music teachers and other authorities. This deliberate refusal by many students to learn music has reduced the knowledge of music the students have in many areas. As revealed through the findings of the study, educational qualification of the teacher has significant influence on the level of musical apathy by students. The implication of this to digital economy is that more stringent measures will be adopted by government and private school owners in the qualification demands of music teachers and as such, more qualified teachers will be employed or recruited which will consequently help many students to have proper knowledge of music and contribute positively towards the direct or digitalized economy of the nation. Apart from this, there is also an implication that general qualities of the teacher will be considered in the process of recruiting music teacher. All these will be geared towards the development of the economy physically or digitally.

Furthermore, it is pertinent to state categorically that being rich or poor does not determine the interest of students in music. In other words, the implication is that both rich and poor students could develop lack of interest in music education. This finding of the study could come because economic status may not really determine how successful an individual student could be in music study. It could also be that looking at the music industry in Nigeria and successes of musical artistes especially in Nigeria, students have realized that both students from poor or rich background can be successful in the music industry. Hence, they are fully aware that economic or social status cannot boost their interest in music.

This finding of the study is not surprising to the researcher because musical icons do not need to be highly or lowly placed before they can make impact. In other words, the researcher is not surprised because the concept of interest is psychological and has nothing to do with the social standing of an individual. That means that people from high status homes as well as those from low status homes may lack interest in studying music education. The finding of the study is similar to that reported by Engel (2005) who noted that social economic status has an insignificant influence on students' interest in music in secondary schools.

It further reveals that the academic qualification of a teacher in terms of first, second or third degree may influence the interest of students in studying music education. By implication, this means that students may develop interest in studying music depending on the exposure of the teacher that comes with their educational qualifications. From the finding, it is revealed that student show more music apathy by their mean scores when taught by teachers with less academic qualifications and this means that the more a teacher acquires a higher qualification, the more it may help in boosting the students' interest in music. The finding of the study is expected by the researcher because academic qualification comes with lot of experience which can help in the teaching-learning process.

Teachers should consider how they can involve parents in ways that help them feel included by honoring their schedules, opinions, and contributions. Parents may appreciate attending open houses where they can interact with music teachers and learn about the program. Because some parents and guardians may have limited Internet access, it is important that hard copy invitations for open houses and all important events be delivered to families. Considering that parents might have different work schedules (e.g., day, night, overnight), music teachers could exercise flexibility in scheduling musical open houses.

This might include multiple open houses at different times of the day as well as evenings. Because parents may have had negative past experiences with school music or harbor false assumptions about the music program, interacting with them on a personal level and informing them about options for their child may help to build bridges. Interacting with parents will also help teachers become aware of the ways parents could become involved with the program. For example, parents could help with concerts (e.g., accompanying, lighting, organizing refreshments), chaperoning trips, or fundraising.

Conclusion

Studying music as a subject or course as well as taking it up as profession has always been a subject of controversy between the adolescents and parents. While some believe that they may not need to be rooted in the rudiments of music as a subject before attaining fame, some on the other hand believe otherwise. In the first scenario, where parents may try to interfere in the choice of studying music, this has degenerated into music education apathy where majority of the students lose interest in studying music. However, some factors could be responsible for this as this study reveals. While economic factor may not account for this, teachers' low qualifications, low career prospect and teachers' teaching methods are sure determinants of these ill in secondary schools especially in Nigeria.

Recommendations

Here are plausible recommendations on how to curtail music appreciation challenges in Secondary Schools in Nigeria.

1. Strengthen music education by making music appreciation a compulsory component of the secondary school curriculum and ensuring effective implementation.
2. Recruit qualified music teachers to teach music appreciation in secondary schools and provide regular professional development through workshops, seminars, and training.
3. Provide adequate instructional materials, including musical instruments, audio-visual equipment, music textbooks, recordings, and digital learning resources.
4. Increase government funding for music education to improve facilities, purchase teaching aids, and support practical music activities.
5. Establish well-equipped music rooms and laboratories where students can engage in listening exercises, instrumental practice, and music appreciation activities.

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